Resilience Often Arises from Ordinary Adaptive Systems

Resilience in development commonly depends on ordinary systems—relationships, regulation, competence, and community resources—not rare invulnerability; adversity is not harmless.

HIGH-EXISTENCE; MODERATE-MECHANISM; LOW-COSTLESS | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: RESILIENCE, SYSTEMS | REPLICATION: V

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Many children facing serious adversity later function within typical ranges. Masten (2001) argued that this is usually "ordinary magic": resilience processes ride on common adaptive systems—attachment relationships, cognitive competence, self-regulation, and community resources—rather than rare, heroic traits. Kauai and related cohorts are historical illustrations, not this card's identification.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Narrative synthesis of a research program, not a new RCT. Causal support for some protective processes comes from caregiving and placement trials already on other cards (BEIP; attachment-intervention sensitivity). This card does not re-estimate those packages. Sleep and screen theory are not restated.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

There is no portable d for "resilience." Heterogeneity is the finding: some high-risk children do well, many remain affected, and recovery can be domain-specific.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (systemic adaptive framework, not an observational population phenotype association).

Who is counted as "resilient" depends on which outcome and which threshold. Survivorship and WEIRD-sample limits apply. Severe, chronic deprivation is a different identification (BEIP).

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Resilience does not mean adversity is harmless, that every child bounces back, or that families should be asked to compensate for missing housing, income, or safety. It does not identify "invulnerable" children.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Strengthen ordinary supports (stable relationships, safety, learning opportunities) and reduce structural load. Searching for exceptional child traits as the policy is not justified.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Masten (2001), American Psychologist